

The Declaration of Independence

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Analyze Foundational Documents: Theme and Rhetorical Features (LINES 8–17)

A text's theme, or main meaning, can be stated directly or must be inferred.

CITE TEXT EVIDENCE Read lines 8–17 and identify the main subject of the passage.

(identifying people's rights under government)

Look for a word or phrase that best describes or summarizes Jefferson's opinion of the main subject.

("[W]henver any form of government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the right of the people to alter or abolish it, and to institute a new government. . . ." [lines 13–15])

Restate the theme.

(People have a right to a government that respects their rights, the right to overturn a government that does not, and the right to establish a new one.)

Analyze Structure: Style and Content (LINES 28–31)

A writer expresses style through word choice, sentence length, and tone—the writer’s attitude toward the subject.

CITE TEXT EVIDENCE: Identify the words in lines 28–31 that have the strongest connotations, or emotional impact.

(repeated injuries and usurpations, absolute tyranny)

Why Jefferson might have chosen these words.

(to emphasize how badly the British government was treating the colonies)

Reread the lines and describe Jefferson’s tone, citing supporting words and phrases.

Analyze Foundational Documents: Theme and Rhetorical Features (LINES 32–58)

Rhetorical features include all the methods a writer uses to communicate ideas and appeal to readers. One rhetorical feature is repetition, repeating words and phrases to reinforce meaning and to create rhythm.

CITE TEXT EVIDENCE: Read this page and identify what is repeated.

(“He has” at the beginning of each sentence)

What effect this repetition has on the reader.

(It emphasizes the king’s many offenses, creating a rhythm that hammers home the point to readers.)

Analyze Structure: Style and Content (LINES 42–47)

Syntax is the way words, phrases, and clauses are arranged in sentences. Repeating the opening words (“He has”) of these sentences might have dulled their impact over time, failing to keep the reader’s interest. Instead, Jefferson varies the rhythm and content of the words that follow them. The phrase “for the sole purpose of fatiguing them into compliance with his measure” in lines 44–45. How this phrase enlivens the sentence by varying its rhythm and adding information about the king’s actions—in this case, about his motivation.

CITE TEXT EVIDENCE: Reread lines 42–47 and find another phrase that tells about an action.

(“with manly firmness,” line 47)

Read the sentence without the phrase and then tell how the phrase affects the rhythm of the sentence.

(It breaks up the sentence’s rhythm, making readers pause to pay attention.)

Then ask students how they think this phrase engages the reader’s sympathies.

(By characterizing the representatives’ opposition as “manly” and “firm,” both positive qualities, Jefferson makes the reader feel that they must be in the right.)

Analyze Structure: Style and Content

(LINES 90–97)

Tone is the writer's attitude toward the subject. The use of words with strong connotations, or emotional associations, expresses the author's tone.

CITE TEXT EVIDENCE: Read lines 90–97 aloud. Paraphrase these sentences using neutral language.

(The King is sending in foreign troops to subdue the colonies. He has forced colonists taken into custody at sea to serve in his occupying army.)

Describe Jefferson's actual tone.

(indignant, even angry)

Which specific words contribute most to this tone.

(desolation, tyranny: line 91; cruelty, perfidy: line 92; barbarous: line 93; executioners: line 96; brethren: line 97)

Analyze Foundational Documents: Rhetorical Features (LINES 107–114)

Parallelism is the use of similar grammatical structures to emphasize the relationship among ideas or show that they have equal weight or importance.

Read lines 107–114, noticing examples of parallelism. Then, work with partners, taking turns reading these lines aloud. Allow time for partners to compare and contrast the effect of the parallelism when read silently and heard aloud.

CITE TEXT EVIDENCE: Cite examples of parallelism.

(Each sentence begins with the subject “we” followed by a present perfect tense verb: “We have warned them; We have reminded them; We have appealed to their native justice; we have conjured them.” All but the second to last follow the verb with the pronoun “them.”)

Then ask how these ideas are related.

(They are ways the founders have tried to resolve their problems with Britain peacefully.)

Analyze Structure: Style and Content (LINES 111–114)

Jefferson chose his words carefully to achieve his purpose of convincing “a candid world” to support American independence.

CITE TEXT EVIDENCE: List the words in these lines that help Jefferson persuade readers that the colonists have done their best to work with the British people.

(native justice, magnanimity, conjured, common kindred)

Analyze Foundational Documents: Theme and Rhetorical Features (LINES 123–130)

In these lines Jefferson combines parallelism and repetition to reinforce his theme.

CITE TEXT EVIDENCE: Find examples of parallelism and repetition in this paragraph.

(parallelism: clauses beginning with “that” in lines 123, 124, 125, and 127; repetition: “ought to be” in lines 124 and 127)

State Jefferson’s theme, and how these devices reinforce it.

(Jefferson’s theme is that the colonies are now independent. The clauses beginning with that emphasize the separation. The repetition of ought to be reinforces the idea that independence is justified.)

Analyze Structure: Style and Content (LINES 119–133)

Both word choice and syntax contribute to a writer's tone. Read the final paragraph of The Declaration of Independence. Discuss general impressions of Jefferson's attitude toward his topic.

CITE TEXT EVIDENCE: Describe Jefferson's tone in lines 119–133.

(Possible answers: direct, reverent, confident, determined)

What words help create the tone?

(Possible answers: solemnly, publish and declare, absolved, free and independent, full power, of right)

How does the syntax help create the tone?

(The arrangement of Jefferson's words, phrases, and clauses in long sentences makes the language formal and creates a confident and determined tone that embodies the seriousness and firmness of the colonies' decision to declare independence.)

Critical Vocabulary

establish: to formally set up. Jefferson warns that an existing government should not be changed impulsively. What is the advantage of maintaining an established government? *(An established government ensures stability and order.)*

affect: to cause or influence. Because of the King's actions and decisions, British soldiers were not accountable to the government of the colonies. How the King's empowerment of British soldiers affected the colonists. *(The colonists had no way to defend themselves from the actions of British soldiers.)*

invest: to grant or endow. Quebec claimed it had been granted power to govern parts of the colonies. Why Jefferson rejects the idea that Quebec was invested by Great Britain with the power to legislate for the colonies. *(Quebec can't be endowed, or invested, with this power because Great Britain cannot grant something it does not rightfully have.)*

abdicate: to relinquish or cede responsibility for. Jefferson argues that the King gave up his right to govern the colonies. How the King's actions show that he has abdicated his role as a trustworthy leader by acting like a tyrant. *(The king's actions include increasing the military's power over the colonies, imposing taxes on them, deporting colonists, and destroying colonists' land and property without recourse. His actions indicate that he established unjust, punitive policies, abdicating his responsibility to treat the colonies fairly.)*